MOUNTAIN REVIEW

OFFICIAL NEWSLETTER OF THE MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION

Volume XIII Issue IV Fall 2023

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Celebrating Shoreline



THE PAST, PRESENT, & FUTURE OF THE SHORELINE REGIONAL PARK COMMUNITY

Our Fall 2023 Event

In 2023, Shoreline at Mountain View is celebrating its 40th anniversary. In honor of this milestone, we are excited to welcome staff from the City of Mountain View's Shoreline Regional Park division as our special guest speakers. They will share what is sure to be a fascinating and informative slideshow presentation on the past, present and future of the Shoreline Regional Park Community, which includes Shoreline at Mountain View. The Shoreline Regional Park Community, also known as the North Bayshore Area, is the area of Mountain View located north of the Bayshore Freeway (U.S. 101). This area has gone through significant changes from ranches, to ports for scow schooners, to an auto wrecking yard and hog farm; and that was all before Shoreline at Mountain View or the Shoreline Regional Park Community was even created. Shoreline at Mountain View is the 750-acre wildlife and recreation area built over 544 acres of a closed landfill in the northern-most part of Mountain View on the edge of the San Francisco Bay.

In addition to reviewing the past land uses of the area, the presentation will also cover the decisions and infrastructure needs that shaped the current Shoreline Community into a tech hub with an amphitheater and regional park. It will also provide some brief updates on the future plans for Shoreline including bolstering environmental biodiversity and wildlife preservation while addressing sea level rise and providing much needed housing to the region.

Our Guest Speaker



BRADY RUEBUSCH

Brady Ruebusch is the Shoreline Manager for the City of Mountain View. He has bachelors of arts in urban studies & planning and political science from UC San Diego as well as a master of arts in urban planning from UCLA. Brady was born and raised in Mountain View and even served on the City's Youth Advisory Group (now Youth Advisory Commission) while in high school. He was hired as the Senior Management Analyst in the Community Services Department in 2015 and moved into his role of Shoreline Manager in 2019. As Shoreline Manager, Brady oversees environmental programs, patrolling (ranger) programs, recreation programs, as well as the operators of Shoreline's many facilities including the golf course and Shoreline Amphitheatre. In addition, Brady works closely with staff from other city departments, contractors, and governmental agencies who perform work within the North Bayshore Area. Brady proudly serves in support of these multiple partners and goals while ensuring they honor the legacy and vision of the Shoreline area.

Sunday, November 12, 2023 ● 2:00 to 4:00 p.m. ● The Historic Adobe Building 157 Moffett Blvd., Mtn. View CA

REGISTER ONLINE: http://mvhistory.eventbrite.com

News & Notes

President's Message

By Pamela Baird
MVHA President



Pamela Baird

So much history!

One advantage of having so many small cities on the peninsula is that each community has a unique history that residents want to chronicle, preserve and display. Instead of larger cities that may not detail local history on a more minute level, smaller cities can save and share history made in small increments.



New Museum of Los Gatos

Better yet, many local cities have small museums (sometimes located in historic properties), or history centers located in public buildings (the Mountain View History Center is located in the Library). Board member Carol Donahue and I recently visited the New Museum in Los Gatos. The facility is located in the former city library building. Last year the museum opened a Los Gatos History Project section. The museum has done a great job of detailing the founding of the city, local colorful characters and a timeline of events. This exhibit closes December 31 and is worth a visit. For more information see: www.numulosgatos.org/exhibitions-2/2022/lghp-uncovering-untold-stories.



San Mateo County History Museum Dome

A recent visit to the San Mateo County History Museum in Redwood City was a real treat. The restored 1910 courthouse contains both permanent and changing exhibits. The history of the county is well detailed. If you plan to visit, allow several hours to view everything. The building is a real architectural gem with a dome filled with beautiful stained glass panels and a mosaic tile floor. The building is listed on the National Register of Historic Places. For more information visit: www.historysmc.org/exhibits

Closer to us is the Los Altos History Museum. This great resource contains a wonderful interactive permanent exhibit covering the local history of Los Altos (and some of Mountain View as well). The upcoming exhibit (November 9-February 25, 2024) will provide fun viewing: the history of El Camino Real To learn more, visit: www.losaltoshistory.org/exhibit/el-camino-real/.

Our neighbor to the north, Palo Alto, will soon have its own museum facility. Their collection will be displayed in the historic Roth Building, designed by the respected architect Birge Clark. The museum is a public-private partnership with the City of Palo Alto. It is planned to open by the end of 2024. For more information visit: www.paloaltohistorymuseum.org/the-museum.

There are many other options for learning about the history of the surrounding area. Whatever the source, there is much that can be learned by a visit to an actual location or sitting at your computer visiting websites. So, start searching, it's so interesting what one can learn!

—Pamela

This newsletter is published four times a year by the
MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION
P.O. Box 252, Mountain View, CA 94042
www.mountainviewhistorical.org

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MVHA Outreach Updates

By Carol Donahue
MVHA Director-at-Large

Your MVHA Board of Directors has been hard at work sharing our local history at community events! Read on for some quick recaps:

The Harvest History Festival on September 16 at Heritage Park was sponsored by the Kiwanis Club and the City of Mountain View. This family-friendly morning celebrated the rich agricultural past of Mountain View. The park is home to the Soil & Water Garden, a community space where people can gather, garden, create and learn from each other. Live bluegrass music by the Stragglers sent forth a neighborly, country mood.

MVHA board members, Robert Cox, Pamela Baird, and Carol Donahue set up a public engagement table with local history displays, books for sale and free historical drawings for children to color. Visitors included a young couple and their baby who recently moved from Southern California to Mountain View. They had many questions about Mountain View history. The new mother, an elementary school educator, will spend part of her parental leave studying *Milestones: a History of Mountain View, California* by Mary Jo Ignoffo. She will use the resource for the history portion of her curriculum when she returns to a classroom.

Shoreline's 40th Celebration on October 15 was five hours of fun, including antique vehicle displays, carnival games and Tom Petty cover band, Petty. The Mountain View Historical Association's booth displayed poster-sized Shoreline planning maps and historical photos as well as a binder of historical photos put together by David Salinero. A special area was set aside for children to color a drawing of Rengstorff House. Photos of events and places were set out for people to view.

Thanks to the Chamber of Commerce, we had a booth at this year's **Art & Wine Festival** and look forward to doing so again in the future. Speaking of downtown, our **Downtown Walking Tours** have continued most months of the year, with more planned in the future! And we also continue to set up our info booth at neighborhood ice cream socials throughout the city. Stay tuned for a more in-depth articles on these outreach activities in future newsletters!

Social Media outreach efforts continue to be led by Jerry Steach and Pamela Baird. They post once a week on Facebook, Twitter (X) and Nextdoor about national days of interest with photographs from our archives. Popular posts have included information about National Aviation Day with a photo of a plane approaching Moffett Field, the 1895 Fourth of July parade on Castro Street and National Prune Day with a photo of plums drying in the sun on the Emerson Ranch. Follow MVHA here: https://www.facebook.com/MVHistory https://twitter.com/MtnViewHistory



MVHA President Pamela Baird, MVHA Director-at-Large Carol Donahue, and MVHA Member David Salinero at our booth during Shoreline's 40th Celebration.



MVHA President Pamela Baird, MVHA Director-at-Large Carol Donahue, and MVHA Vice President Robert Cox at the Harvest History Festival at Heritage Park.



Some younger guests enjoy filling in our MVHA coloring pages at Shoreline's 40th anniversary celebration.

Financial Report

By Pamela Baird & Melissa Rusch
MVHA President & MVHA Treasurer

Checking Account Balance as of 3/31/2023: $17,501.52
Checking Account Balance as of 9/30/2023: $19,557.38
Income: $4,741
Expenses: $2,699
Key expenditures: Book purchase, newsletters, Zoom fees, printing materials
Key income: Membership, Donations, book sales, walking tours

Certificates of Deposit: $60,615.22

Summer Event Recap



For our summer event on August 6 the MVHA welcomed Kevin Ferguson as our featured guest speaker. Kevin shared 100 years of Mountain View history through the stories of his winemaking family, the Gemellos. For much of the 20th Century the Gemellos operated their family winery on El Camino Real in Mountain View while dealing with the city's growth. Kevin's stories will soon be shared in his forthcoming book *Rain on the Monte Bello Ridge, a memoir about health, aging and winemaking*. If you missed his talk and want to learn more, early release chapters are already available for those who sign up for his free newsletter at https://gemello.substack.com/.

...and while we didn't serve wine at the event (it was considered!), we celebrate summer with our annual ice cream social. A special thanks to John McAlister who donated ice cream from his Baskin-Robbins shop on El Camino Real for a second year in a row! We were pleased to have another full Adobe Building at the event and hope to see many of you again in November!



Members of the Gemello family at our event. From left to right: Pat (Gemello) Ferguson, our guest speaker Kevin Ferguson holding a vintage bottle of Gemello wine, John Gemello, and Linda Gemello.



Members and guests enjoyed ice cream and the beautiful summer weather on the Adobe Building's patio.



MVHA Membership Director Lisa Garcia (left) and daughter Angelica Garcia welcome attendees.



MVHA Vice President Robert Cox shares his closing remarks.

Finding Your Family History

By Robert Cox
MVHA Vice President

Any genealogy researcher should be aware of the basic laws and rules governing the accessibility and displaying of personal information. In addition to being legally compliant, those posting genealogical information should show common courtesy to others.

In general, privacy protections of someone's personal data apply only to a person referenced and only while he or she is living. I first studied genealogy in Texas in the 1990s, and my teacher put it this way: "Here in Texas, we all think that what our daddy or granddaddy did reflects upon us, but there is no legal way for you to keep someone from publishing some true fact about him, especially if he is dead."

The rules governing the organizing and displaying of genealogical information changed abruptly when the European Union passed the General Data Protection Regulation in 2016. With its passage, displaying information about any citizen of a European Union country, or any person employed by a company based in such a country became illegal, without first seeking that person's permission. This led the leaders of the Wikitree genealogical project, of which I am a contributor, to privacy-protect all data associated with living people on their site. The project leaders also do not allow photos of people, living or dead, to be posted on the site unless the photos' owner grants permission. This is true even if the photos are posted on a public website or social media site like Facebook or Instagram.

Laws governing the accessibility of public records try to balance the desire of researchers to learn with the public's desire to protect its privacy. Federal census records are sealed for 72 years after the census is taken. Laws governing the release of birth, marriage, and death records vary by state. For example, it is relatively easy to access these records for older living people Texas and California, while some other states make them almost impossible to access.

When posting information on a genealogical website, consider the people who might be affected by it. Including a person's criminal record, marital infidelities, or reporting the circumstance of that person's untimely death could be embarrassing to the family.

In my next column, I will cover genealogy software.



The Stierlin Ranch House circa 1964, now the location of the Mountain View Microsoft Campus

Mtn. View Family History Fun Fact!



C. C. Stierlin at his ranch, c. 1889, with daughter Marguerite and grandson Conrad Jansen.

Peter Stierlin, a great-grandson of the brother of Mountain View pioneer, Conrad Christoph Stierlin, is a retired publisher living in Switzerland who became acquainted with his family's Mountain View heritage in a surprising way. Peter was inspired to research his possible connection to Mountain View's Stierlin family by an inquiry about a magazine subscription he received with the Stierlin Rd., Mountain View, CA address.

C. C. Stierlin was born in 1828 in Switzerland and left his homeland for the port of New Orleans, Louisiana, arriving in 1842. Working as a mechanic, he traveled to various locations throughout the USA, eventually reaching Santa Clara County in 1851. In 1864, he purchased a 164-acre plot near the current intersection of Shoreline Blvd. and La Avenida. C. C. Stierlin passed away in 1904, but his ranch house was still standing in the 1960s. The area is now home to Microsoft's Mountain View campus. Shoreline Blvd. was known as Stierlin Rd. until 1987, when it was renamed.

Peter has travelled to Mountain View three times. The first was in 1997. He is shown here standing next to the current Stierlin Rd. and Fountain Park Lane. His latest visit was in 2015, where he is shown next to the tombstone of C. C. Stierlin. That tombstone was moved from Mountain View to the Santa Clara Mission Cemetery, when the land in Mountain View was redeveloped.



Peter Stierlin at the corner of Stierlin Road and Fountain Park Lane in 1997



Peter and his friend Jurg at C. C. Stierlin's tombstone in the Santa Clara Mission Cemetery in 2015



Special Feature:

The Evolution of Shoreline Park

A look back on the ambitious plans for a bayfront park in Mtn. View

ABOVE: The ambitious 1968 General Development Plan for Shoreline Regional Park included some features that were built like a boating lake and golf course, but many that were shelved as priorities shifted to more nature-focused recreation. These never-built features visible on the plan include a sports area, equestrian area, zoo, aerial tram, puppet show theatre, aquarium, children's playland and more.

By David P. Salinero
MVHA Member

This year Shoreline Park is celebrating its 40-year anniversary of being open to the public. The park officially opened July 17, 1983. The 750-acre park and its surrounding area has undergone many man-made changes in its history. The first inhabitants of the area were the native Ohlone tribes who lived in the area for centuries before the Europeans arrived. They built villages and hunted and fished in the San Francisco Bay shores. Earth mounds (including the nearby Ynigo mound) from these inhabitants have been found at sites near Shoreline Park. Some San Francisco Bay Ohlone even harvested salt from ponds near the Hayward coast. The Mountain View Historical Association's meeting of November 2022 focused on the history and challenges of the tribes and the Muwekma Ohlone Tribe of the San Francisco Bay Area who still live here today.

Spanish colonists expanded salt pond harvesting during the Mission period. It became a major industry of the Bay Area with approximately 18 family-owned operations during the mid-1800s. But by 1868, Leslie Salt Company had bought up many of the local operators and became the largest landholder in the area. These operations transformed the tidal marshes into salt ponds all around the South Bay. By 1930, about half of the tidal marshes around the South Bay had been converted to salt production. Cargill bought Leslie Salt in 1978 and even today there are still thousands of acres producing salt. The U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service has taken control of the salt ponds just north of Shoreline Park. Today, the salt ponds named A1 and A2W are being restored back to tidal marshes by the Salt Pond Restoration Project.

In the early 1960s, the City of Mountain View bought the land that now makes up Shoreline Park. One of the motivators was to create a park instead of housing as was done in other areas of the bay, such as Foster City. The original General Development Plan for the park was sent to residents in a flyer in 1968. This plan had big ideas and called for a boat lake, marina to the bay, golf course, sports area, and equestrian area. It also mentions a zoo, miniature golf course, theater, and aerial tramway. Some of these amenities were later removed from the final plan. In part, the mailer read:

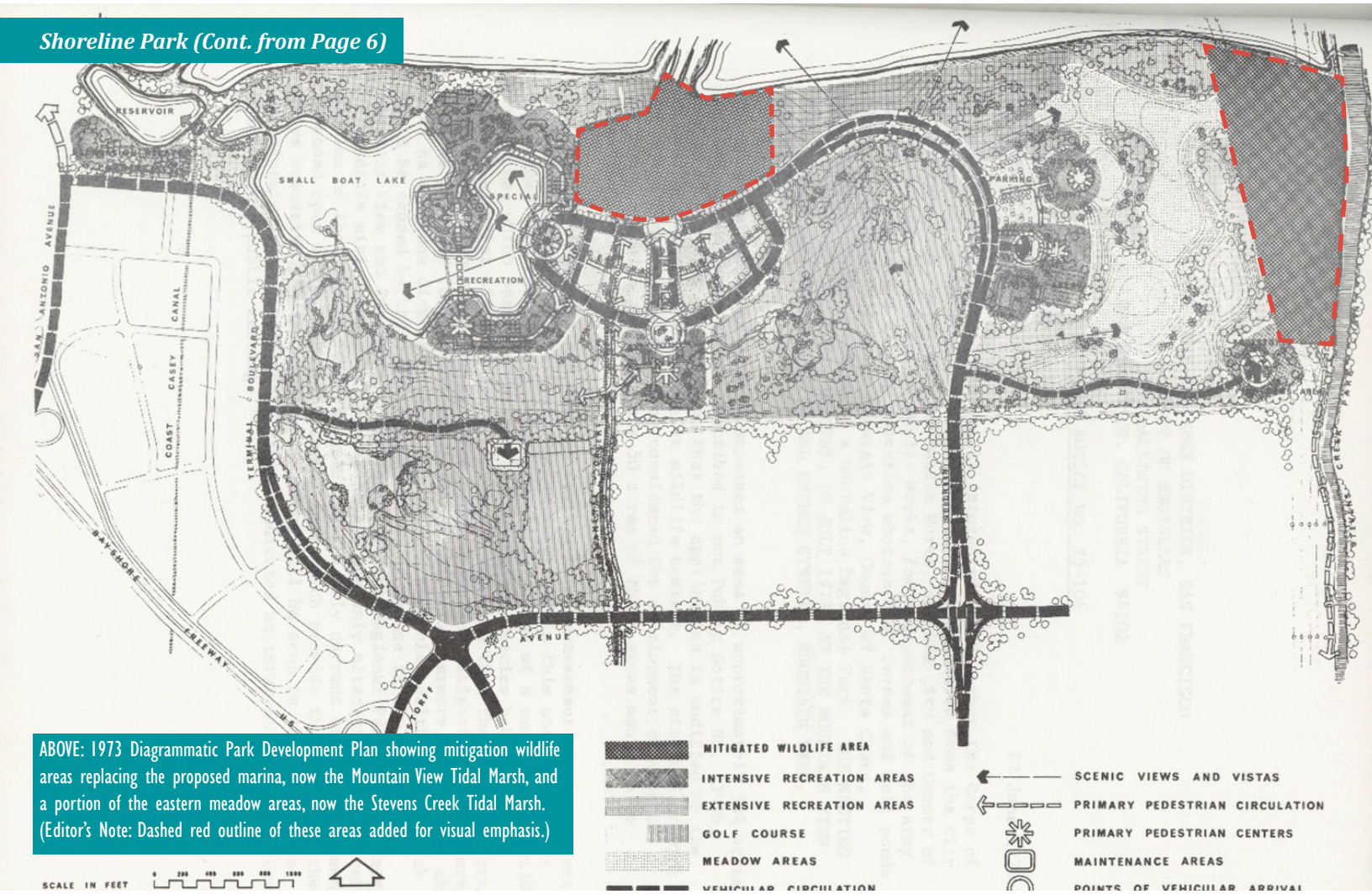
Shoreline Park is an investment in the future for everyone in Mountain View. The benefits that we and our children will derive from the park are incalculable. The recreation and educational opportunities the park will afford will be perpetual repayment for our investment.

According to a historical outline put together by the City in 1973, the area was home to wrecking yards, two substandard dumps, a pig farm, a sewage treatment plant, and low-lying flood lands. If you visited the dump in the 1960s, you noticed it was an early adopter of the "freecycle" movement. You might deposit your old rusty patio furniture and return home with some "perfectly good" used lumber.

The park was approved by U.S. Government agencies and a bond measure in 1966. The original plan was to fill areas with dirt to prevent flooding. This proved to be too expensive. So, in 1970, the City of Mountain View contracted with the City & County of San Francisco to truck tons of garbage to the site to raise the land 15 feet. This would buffer it from flooding.

Continued on next page

Shoreline Park (Cont. from Page 6)



ABOVE: 1973 Diagrammatic Park Development Plan showing mitigation wildlife areas replacing the proposed marina, now the Mountain View Tidal Marsh, and a portion of the eastern meadow areas, now the Stevens Creek Tidal Marsh. (Editor's Note: Dashed red outline of these areas added for visual emphasis.)

Construction was moving along with 18-wheelers making their way to dump their garbage daily to fill in Shoreline Park. But many were not in favor of filling in the tidal marshes. Then in 1971, the Army Corps of Engineers stepped in to claim jurisdiction. They required the city to obtain more permits for unfilled areas of any new work. The city felt the park was not within the jurisdiction of the Corps. But the city wanted to avoid a legal battle and filed for a permit. Two complaints spurred the Corps to issue a "Cease and Desist" order on October 22, 1972.

A public comment meeting was held at the Mountain View High School auditorium on Castro Street on July 10, 1973. Environmental groups had challenged the filling in of two key areas of the park. The Casey Slough, and a 90-acre tidal marshland on the east side of the park. About 400 people showed up for the meeting. Leading up to the meeting a revised plan was floated to save these areas from development. Colonel James L. Lammie, Corps of Engineers, presided over the five hour meeting as government representatives and other speakers presented their views. At one point the audience was asked to stand if they supported a change to the park plan. The local newspapers covered the many twists and turns until a final compromise was reached a few months later. The park would be built, and a few areas would remain as tidal marshes. On a map of present-day Shoreline Park, you can see the natural areas finally saved in the park as "Coast Casey Forebay", "Mountain View Tidal Marsh", and "Stevens Creek Marsh".

Today, the area is still undergoing change. The man-made Shoreline Lake is undergoing improvements to its shore and boat launching areas. In addition, the levees of salt ponds just north of the park are being breached to restore them to tidal areas; An attempt to return some of the land back to the way it was centuries ago.



Dump trucks unload San Francisco's garbage on the future site of Shoreline Park, the hangars of Moffett Field are visible on the horizon.

SHORELINE
AT·MOUNTAIN·VIEW

LEFT: The Shoreline Logo—promotional materials from the park's opening described the logo as "The Great Egret, a graceful bird with a distinct and elegant posture that serves as the symbol for Shoreline, reflects the style directing each phase of Shoreline's development. The rejuvenation of acres of South Bay saltwater marshland and the creation of rolling open meadows at Shoreline is mirrored in the swaying grasses and suggested flight of the great bird featured in the design."

History Happening Now

Mountain View to become Bear Territory



ABOVE: Conceptual rendering of the proposed Berkeley Space Center (gray buildings to right the historic Hangar One) at Moffett Field in Mountain View. Image Source: Field Operations and HOK

BERKELEY SPACE CENTER
AT NASA RESEARCH PARK
AN SKS PARTNERS VENTURE

By Nick Perry
MVHA Past President

The Big Game is still weeks away, but the California Golden Bears are already advancing into arch-rival Stanford's territory. On October 16, the University of California, Berkeley announced a new partnership with the NASA Ames Research Center and SKS Partners that will result in the construction of the "Berkeley Space Center" at Moffett Field in Mountain View.

According to the press release issued by the University of California, the Berkeley Space Center will accommodate up to 1.4 million square feet of research space on 36 acres of land at Moffett Field on land leased from NASA. The new buildings will house state-of-the-art research and development laboratories for companies and UC Berkeley researchers and classrooms for Cal students. The first buildings at the Berkeley Space Center are expected to be ready as soon as 2027.

The development of the Berkeley Space Center is yet another step in the historic evolution of Moffett Field. The land where Moffett Field is now located was once known as Rancho Posolmi, the ranch of Lope Inigo, one of the few native Ohlone to be granted a rancho by the Mexican government. Over the course of his life, Inigo sold portions of his rancho and lost other portions of it to squatters. By the early 20th Century the rancho was subdivided into a number of large ranches where farmers grew broccoli, cauliflower, and hay.

During the Great Depression, cities throughout the Bay Area worked together on a campaign to beat San Diego as the site of the US Navy's new lighter-than-air program and airbase. Fundraising efforts led to the purchase of the former Rancho Posolmi lands, which were then sold to the Navy for $1 for the construction of the base. Originally, the base was to be named Mountain View-Sunnyvale Naval Air Station (NAS) but "Mountain View" was dropped from the name over concerns Washington DC-based officials unfamiliar with the Santa Clara Valley's pastoral geography would be wary of setting up an airship base in a mountain region. The primary purpose of the base was to serve as the west coast home of the Navy's dirigible program. The massive Hangar One was built to house the USS Macon dirigible. Just days before the base opened in 1933, the USS Macon's sister ship the USS Akron crashed into the Atlantic ocean. Two years later, the USS Macon suffered the same fate when it crashed into the Pacific Ocean off the coast of Big Sur. After the loss of the USS Macon, the Navy ended its lighter-than-air program and transferred Moffett Field to the Army Air Corps which used it as a training center for cadets.

In 1940, the National Advisory Committee on Aeronautics (precursor to NASA) opened the Ames Research Center at the base. At the onset of World War II, the base was transferred back to the Navy and rechristened NAS Moffett Field, in honor of Rear Admiral William Moffett who died in the crash of the USS Akron. During the subsequent decades Moffett Field grew to become the Navy's largest air transport base on the west coast. In July 1994, the airfield was closed and Moffett Field was transferred from the Navy to the NASA Ames Research Center. Since then, NASA has worked to redevelop Moffett Field's historic Navy-era military campus area into a research and development park. This new partnership with UC Berkeley builds off existing partnerships with Google (currently restoring Hangar One) and Carnegie Mellon University. If all goes according to plan, come 2027, Mountain View will become part of "Bear Territory" as Cal students and researches affiliated with the Berkeley campus head south and begin making their mark on the long history of Moffett Field.

(*Writer's note: Sorry, Stanford fans...yes, I am biased. Go Bears!*)

Membership

By Lisa Garcia
MVHA Membership Chair

We would like to welcome our new members:

- Doug and Debbie Kundrat
- Kent Randall
- Judy Gee
- Amy Cho & Nicholas Feinberg

Thank you Judy, Amy and Nicholas for becoming lifetime members!

Please remember to email us at membership@mountainviewhistorical.org with any email or address updates so you can keep receiving our newsletters. You can also call me with any questions or updates. We've included here some candid snapshots of our members and guests socializing at the end of our summer event. It was great to see so many familiar and new faces there! We hope to see you again soon!









MEMBERSHIP FORM

The MVHA welcomes new members! You can also join/renew online at **www.mountainviewhistorical.org**. Membership is tax deductible to the extent permitted by law. The MVHA is a tax-exempt organization under Internal Revenue Code Section 501(c)(3), Tax ID 94-6115407.

☐ New Membership

☐ Membership Renewal

☐ Household Annual Membership *$30/year*

☐ Individual Lifetime Membership *$300*

☐ *I'm interested in volunteer opportunities*

Name(s): _____

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Thank you!

FALL/WINTER

November 7
Tuesday, 6:30 p.m. to 8:30 p.m.
MV History 101
Mountain View Public Library, 585 Franklin St.
Join MVHA Past President and local history book author Nick Perry for an overview of Mtn. View's history. Register at: https://mountainview.libcal.com/event/10950254

November 12
Sunday, 2:00 p.m. to 4:00 p.m.
MVHA Fall Meeting
Adobe Building, 157 Moffett Blvd., Mtn. View
See page 1 for more info.

November 19
Sunday, 2:00 p.m. to 3:00 p.m.
Downtown Walking Tours
Centennial Plaza, 600 W. Evelyn Ave, Mtn. View
Details at: http://mvhistory.eventbrite.com

December 13
Wednesday, 6:00 p.m. to 8:00 p.m.
MVHA Board Meeting
Virtual Zoom meeting
All interested members welcome to attend! Email info@mountainviewhistorical.org for log-in

February 4
Sunday afternoon, time TBD
MVHA Spring Event & Meeting
Location TBD
Details in our next newsletter!

Looking Back: Images from the Archives



This aerial image shows Mountain View's North Bayshore district in the 1960s. The Bayshore Highway (US 101) runs along the left side of the image and the salt ponds of the San Francisco Bay are on the upper right. The white asterisk* marks the marshlands that are now the site of Shoreline Sailing Lake. The dark fields of farmland in the center are now largely occupied by the Googleplex. The rural residential area visible below the farm fields were redeveloped with office parks in the 1980s. The large paved area at the bottom center is the Moffett Drive In movie theater, now the site of Mountain View's Cinemark Century 16 cineplex. Just to the left of the drive in is a large warehouse and construction yard which at the time was the headquarters of Arrow Dynamics, a major amusement park ride manufacturer. The road running diagonally on the right is Stierlin Road, now named North Shoreline Boulevard. The lone red tile roof building on the right side of Stierlin was home to Whisman Elementary School.

EST. 1954
MOUNTAIN REVIEW
MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION
P.O. Box 252
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